

The Map

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The Fallen Lieutenant was not a game for the faint-hearted.

It was not, strictly speaking, a game for anyone with good sense — the deck was old enough that some of the cards had developed opinions of their own about which way they faced, and the scoring system had been explained to Blackhoof three times by three different people and had arrived each time as a completely different game. What he understood was this: points accumulated, hands were laid, and the man with the most at the end either went home considerably richer or had not been paying enough attention.

Briggs had been paying attention since before Blackhoof was born.

The inn was called something in the local language that nobody had bothered to translate, and it was warm in the specific way of rooms that had been warm for a very long time. Low beams. A fire that knew its job. Four men around a table that had hosted worse arguments than this one and bore the scars to prove it.

Gogo — goblin lieutenant, third battalion, invited because he had coins — sat with his cards held up to his nose and his brow furrowed in the expression of a man trying to read a language he had been assured he spoke. He had been losing steadily since the second hand with the cheerful consistency of someone who didn't entirely understand what losing meant yet.

Leafel Greenleaf occupied the chair to his left with the easy grace of a man who treated every room as a stage specifically constructed for his benefit. He was an elf of middle years by elven accounting, which meant he looked approximately thirty and had opinions about everything. His cards sat in his hand like a fan at a summer court, and he had not stopped talking since he sat down.

"And here," he said, as the fourth hand was dealt, "we see the sergeant arrange his cards with the focused intensity of a man defusing something. Remarkable. Truly. The beard. The stillness. One might think he was reading scripture."

"One might," said Blackhoof, from his place behind Briggs's left shoulder, "think he was trying very hard not to throw the cards at someone."

"The thought has occurred to me," Briggs said, without looking up.

"And yet the cards remain in his hand," Leafel observed. "Extraordinary self-control. I've seen lesser men crack under far less provocation." He arranged his own hand with a small, satisfied adjustment. "I, of course, am a picture of serenity."

"You haven't stopped talking for forty minutes," Blackhoof said.

"Serenity," Leafel repeated, "takes many forms."

Eldar Josiph Mantel said nothing. He had said very little all evening, which was either the mark of a careful man or a contented one — Blackhoof couldn't decide which, and had been trying to work it out for three hands. The nobleman was somewhere in his middle years, well-dressed without being showy, with the kind of face that invited trust without quite explaining why. He played his cards the way Briggs played his dice: not with luck, but with the patient attention of someone who had been doing this for a very long time and had made his peace with the mathematics of it.

The pile in the centre of the table had been growing since the second hour.

Blackhoof looked at it now and felt something uncomfortable move through his chest. Two good saddle packs. A quality whetstone. His own good hunting knife, which had been wagered — without his explicit consent — somewhere around the sixth hand when Briggs had run short of his own things to offer. A spare pair of bracers, Briggs's best ones. Various coins from various sources.

"Biggs," he said quietly, leaning down.

"Mm."

"That's my knife."

"I know."

"I like that knife."

"Noted."

Blackhoof looked at the pile. He looked at Briggs's cards, which he couldn't understand. He looked at Briggs's face, which told him exactly nothing, which was either reassuring or the opposite.

"How do you know?" he asked.

"I don't," said Briggs. "Be quiet!"

Gogo lasted until the seventh hand.

He laid his cards down with the expression of a man who had just been informed that the language he had been speaking his entire life was in fact a completely different language, pushed back from the table, and stood.

"Good game," he said, to no one in particular. "Very enjoyable." He looked at the pile in the centre with the philosophical acceptance of a man who had been poor before and would manage again. "Good evening to y'all."

He left. Nobody watched him go.

Leafel lasted two hands more. He laid his cards down with considerably more drama — a slow fan, face-up, a small bow to the table at large.

"Gentlemen," he said. "It has been a blast! Sergeant — " he looked at Briggs with something that was almost respect, "I have played this game in fourteen cities on three continents, and I have never watched a man lose so consistently in the early hands and win so thoroughly in the late ones without being absolutely certain he was cheating. I am not certain you were cheating. This disturbs me more than if I were."

"Good night," said Briggs, eyes cold as a tombstone.

"And yet the warmth I feel—"

"Goodnight, Leafel."

The elf stood, collected his coat, and paused behind Blackhoof's shoulder on his way to the door.

"Your sergeant," he said quietly, with genuine seriousness, "is either very good or very lucky, and in my experience those are the same thing." He glanced at the table. "Back him."

Then he was gone, and the inn was quieter, and it was just the two of them.

Briggs and Eldar Josiph Mantel looked at each other across the table.

Mantel smiled — small, genuine, the smile of a man who had arrived at the interesting part of the evening. He picked up his cards and arranged them once, briefly, and set them down again.

"Well then," he said.

"Well then," said Briggs.

"Well?" Blackhoof almost fainted from the pressure.

Noone noticed him.

Centaur didn't know the game. That was the fundamental problem. He could see the cards going down, could see numbers and symbols, could track in a broad sense that points were accumulating — but whether the cards Briggs held were good or catastrophic or something in between was entirely beyond him, and Briggs's face was offering no assistance whatsoever.

Leafel's running commentary, at least, had given him something to anchor to. Without it, he was adrift.

He watched Briggs reach into his coat.

The medal came out slowly — dark ribbon, the weight of it, the shine of metal that had been earned rather than bought. Briggs set it on the pile in the centre of the table without ceremony, the way a man set down a tool he had finished using.

Blackhoof's jaw tightened.

Mantel looked at the medal for a moment. Then he reached into his own coat and produced a folded piece of paper, aged at the edges, and laid it beside the medal.

"Map," he said simply. "To a location of some interest."

Briggs glanced at it. Glanced at the pile — the packs, the knife, the bracers, everything accumulated over the evening.

"Fine," he said.

Blackhoof looked at the pile. He looked at Briggs. He looked at Mantel, who was arranging his cards with the unhurried attention of a man who believed the next few minutes would go in his favour.

He thought about saying something.

He didn't. The pressure of the moment took all his breath away.

The final hand was played in silence, which was its own kind of noise. Cards went down. Points accumulated. Blackhoof tracked the face-up cards with desperate attention and understood approximately none of what he was seeing. Briggs's expression had not changed since the beginning of the evening. Mantel's hadn't either.

Then Briggs laid his last card.

Mantel looked at it.

He laid his own.

Briggs counted. Once, with the flat attention of a man confirming arithmetic he already knew. Then he reached out and drew the pile toward him with both hands, the steady movement of a man collecting something that was already his.

Mantel looked at the empty table in front of him for a moment. Then he laughed — short, genuine, the laugh of a man who had lost to someone worth losing to.

"Well played, Sergeant. One of the most interesting games I have played in my life!"

"Thanks," said Briggs, counting. No more words, but his posture radiated satisfaction.

The map was the last thing he unfolded, back at the camp that evening, with the fire low and Blackhoof leaning over his shoulder with unconcealed interest.

It was hand-drawn, precise, the kind of careful work that suggested someone had spent time on it. A road. A crossroads. A series of markers: a stone formation, a tree with a symbol carved into it, a count of paces, a small building at the end marked with a cross.

"That crossroads," Blackhoof said slowly. "We passed it yesterday."

Briggs looked at him. Then at the map.

"Yes, we did," he said slowly. Some idea has started to incubate in his skull.

Gord gave Briggs the leave without much discussion — the army had nothing planned, the weather was reasonable, and Briggs had the expression of a man who was going regardless. They left at first light with the map, their recovered equipment, and Blackhoof's knife back at his belt where it belonged.

The crossroads was exactly where the map said it would be.

"Right," said Briggs, orienting the map. "Stone formation, northeast. Then—" he squinted—"forty paces to the marked tree."

"Forty paces," Blackhoof said. "Whose paces?"

"Paces."

"That's not an answer. Your paces are — " Blackhoof considered the geometry — "about here." He indicated somewhere near his knee. "My paces are considerably longer. We'll end up in different countries."

"We'll end up at a tree," Briggs said. "Start walking."

"But if we—"

"Blacky."

"I'm just saying the mathematics—"

"Walk."

Centaur walked. He counted. Briggs walked beside him, also counting, at a pace that covered perhaps sixty percent of the same ground per step. By the time Blackhoof reached forty, Briggs was somewhere around twenty-eight and showing no signs of agreement.

"Forty," Blackhoof announced.

"Not yet," said Briggs, still walking.

"I'm at forty."

Gnome didn't answer, just walked further.

By the time Briggs has reached forty, Blackhoof already gave up somewhere over fifty five. His snorting couldn't have sounded more dismissive.

"You have the stride of something that lives on a steppe. We're looking for something built by a person, not a horse."

"I'm not a horse—"

In a moment they were both standing in front of an oak tree of considerable age that had, carved into its bark at roughly gnome eye height, a rune that matched the symbol on the map exactly.

They both looked at it.

"Right," said Briggs.

"So the paces were—"

"Irrelevant."

"You could just say I was right."

"Hmmm," Briggs agreed, already consulting the map for the next marker.

The chapel was small. Just a place where someone saw some deity years ago and decided to claim this place holy. Some old grannies from the village still brought some flowers and some offerings - grain, nuts, whatever. The whole structure was somehow crooked. But it was the exact place, where big red X was on the map.

Briggs saw it immediately (after considerable amount of walking around, watching for a clue). And a candlestick, on the altar, which was wrong.

Blackhoof could tell by the way gnome stopped and tilted his head, the expression he used for things that were pretending to be something they weren't. He reached the altar and looked at the candlestick for a moment without touching it.

Then he turned it.

The sound the chapel made was enormous in the silence — stone grinding against stone, a mechanism that had been waiting patiently for this exact moment, the whole structure shifting and rotating and settling with a solidity that suggested it had been doing this for years and intended to keep doing it.

Where the chapel had stood, there was now a pit. And at the bottom of the pit, a chest!

They looked at each other.

The chest was unlocked. Briggs lifted the lid, and they both looked inside.

The expression on their faces has changed. Fast and slowly in the same time. They were expecting something, but definitely not the result they have got.

Inside was empty except for a single rolled scroll at the bottom, sealed with red wax.

Briggs moved the ribbon with the seal away and unrolled the scroll.

He read it once. Then he held it up so Blackhoof could read it.

If you have found this chest, congratulations — you have followed a map I have been placing into card games for several years now. I hope the journey was pleasant. With respect and enduring affection, ever yours — Eldar Josiph Mantel.

PS: Please, place the scroll back and close the chapel the same way - there will be more adventurers coming. Thank you in advance.

Silence.

"Years," Blackhoof said.

"Mm."

"Several years."

"Mm."

Briggs rolled the scroll back up with the precise, controlled movements of a man making decisions about his emotional response. He put it back into the chest. Then looked down one more time, then looked at Blackhoof, whose expression was doing something that Briggs identified as the precursor to laughter and regarded accordingly.

"Don't," Briggs said.

Blackhoof pressed his lips together.

"It's not—"

The sound that came out of Blackhoof was not quite a laugh. It was the sound of a laugh that had been very firmly instructed not to exist and had compromised. He turned away, which helped neither of them. Blackhoof turned the candlestick and Chapel moved back.

"The man," Briggs said, with precision, "has been sending people — soldiers, presumably, men with weapons and training — on a day-long walk to an empty chest. For years." He paused. "For years."

"He really loves the game," Blackhoof managed.

"He loves—" Briggs stopped. Something shifted in his face, briefly, in the direction of a man who has encountered something so spectacularly pointless that it has come all the way around to impressive. "Right," he said.

"We got all our things back though," Blackhoof offered.

"We did."

"Your medal. And my knife."

"Mm."

A pause. "And had a very pleasant walk."

Briggs looked at him with an expression that was not quite the one he was aiming for, because something at the corner of his mouth was failing to cooperate.

"Don't push it."

Blackhoof looked for one more moment on the chapel and the candlestick sitting innocently back in its original position, and he thought about Eldar Josiph Mantel sitting across a card table with his trustworthy face and his well-worn map, and then he followed Briggs out into the afternoon, smiling the whole way.

They were most of the way back to camp, when Blackhoof said it.

"Biggs."

"Mm."

"This kind of life." He looked at the road ahead, the treeline, the open sky. "Finding things. Following maps. Poking around in old places." He paused. "I think I'd like it. Sounds fun."

Briggs said nothing.

"Better than fighting someone else's war every morning. Unravelling something, working out the puzzle." He thought of the rune on the tree, the grinding stone, the empty chest with its ridiculous scroll. "Even when the treasure's a letter from a man who thinks he's very funny."

"He is very funny," Briggs said, before he could stop himself.

Blackhoof looked at him.

Briggs looked at the road.

"Serg," Blackhoof said, with the tone of a man who has just won something important. "Did you just—"

"I said nothing." Briggs walked on. "Keep moving."

Blackhoof kept moving, and said nothing more, and did not push it, but he was smiling for the rest of the way home and Briggs saw that smile. And something inside him moved a little.

